CHLORPROMAZINE

Highly sedating
Photosensitivity

CHEMICAL NAME 3-(2-chloro-10H-phenothiazin-10-yl)-N,N-dimethylpropan-1-amine (hydrochloride)
CLASS First-generation (typical) phenothiazine antipsychotic
TRADE NAMES Largactil · Thorazine · Chlorpromazine (generic)

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Schizophrenia, mania, severe agitation.
- Intractable hiccups.
- Nausea and vomiting of terminal illness.
- Tetanus (adjunct); childhood schizophrenia.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** tablets/syrup.
- **Deep IM** (painful; patient lying 30 min — hypotension).
- Avoid skin contact with solution (contact dermatitis in staff).

DOSAGES

- **Psychosis:** 25 mg three times daily or 75 mg at night; usual 75–300 mg/day (max 1 g).
- **Hiccups:** 25–50 mg 3–4 times daily.
- **IM:** 25–50 mg every 6–8 h.
- **Elderly:** one-third to half dose.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** PO 30–60 min; IM 15 min. **Duration:** 4–6 h+.
- Extensive first-pass metabolism (CYP2D6), many active metabolites.
- **t½:** ~30 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- **D2** antagonist (low potency) with strong α1, H1, muscarinic blockade → sedation, hypotension, anticholinergic effects.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Sedation, postural hypotension.
- Dry mouth, constipation, blurred vision.
- Photosensitivity; weight gain.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- EPS, tardive dyskinesia; NMS.
- Cholestatic jaundice; agranulocytosis.
- Skin and corneal/lens pigmentation (long-term).
- Seizures; hypothermia.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- CNS depression, coma; bone-marrow suppression.
- Phaeochromocytoma.
- **Caution:** epilepsy, Parkinson's, elderly with dementia, glaucoma.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Alcohol, sedatives:** ↑ sedation.
- **Antihypertensives:** hypotension.
- **Anticholinergics:** additive.
- **Levodopa:** antagonism.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Postural BP; patient lying after IM.
- Monitor EPS, temperature, LFTs, CBC.
- Wear gloves handling liquid.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Avoid strong sunlight; use sunscreen.
- Rise slowly; avoid alcohol and driving.
- Report jaundice, sore throat, stiffness, fever.

KEY POINTS

- Low-potency typical antipsychotic.
- Very sedating, hypotension, anticholinergic.
- Photosensitivity; jaundice.
- Hiccups and agitation.

SOURCES CHECKED **[799]** Chlorpromazine 100mg Tablets (UK SmPC) **[800]** Chlorpromazine, oral (US label) **[801]** Chlorpromazine, oral (US label, Alembic Pharmaceuticals Inc)
Full references p. 432–457